OUR MEDAL

THE FORMIDABLE INDIAN CONTINGENT, BOASTING OVER 620 ATHLETES, IS PRIMED TO COMPETE IN THE HANGZHOU ASIAN GAMES

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Sporting events where a nation's participation is determined less on merit and more because of its geography or a shared colonial past often tend to get less credence than the Olympics. Ignoring the Asian Games, though, is foolish. India has struggled to crack the top five in the Asian Games medal tally, unlike the Commonwealth Games, where it consistently excels. In sports like badminton, table tennis, boxing, weightlifting, wrestling and archery, Indian athletes face the world's best, making it ideal preparation for the Paris Olympics, just 10 months away.

Sony Sports, holding broadcast and streaming rights, has been running its promotion with the slogan *'Iss Baar, Sau Paar...* (This time we cross the 100-medal mark).' Buoyant as the rallying call is, it may seem overtly optimistic given India's performance in the last four Games (see *India at the Asiad).* The country's best showing was in 2018, with 70 medals, including 16 gold, placing it eighth in the table.

Like the 2020 Olympics, the Asian Games were delayed a year due to Covid-19 in host nation China. Now, in Hangzhou (September 23-October 8), the 19th edition features 12,500+ athletes from 45 countries in 40 sports. These include bridge, in which India won gold in 2018, and Asia-friendly sports like kabaddi, wushu, kurash, ju-jitsu and sepaktakraw, where the country indeed has representation. E-sports debuts as a medal event, with India sending 15 gamers. T-20 cricket also makes an entry, though the men's teams lack superstars as the more profitable ODI World Cup takes precedence.

India's contingent has over 620 athletes, with nearly half being female and many quite young. We profile three of them: Aditi Gopichand Swami (archery), Rudrankksh Patil (shooting) and Jeswin Aldrin (long jump). Olympic and world champion Neeraj Chopra is a favourite, but not the only one. Expectations are high for two-time world champion boxer Nikhat Zareen and the world-ranked #2 badminton duo of Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Reddy, who spoke to INDIA TODAY about the significance of the competition. We also shine a light on steeplechase specialist Parul Chaudhary and golfer Aditi Ashok, who missed a medal in Tokyo by a whisker.

Sau paar or not, the Asian Games help boost the profile of range of athletes in this otherwise cricket-obsessed nation. And, at least for two weeks, all eyes will be on them. ■